millions Down Under watched him fail miserably at cheating a game away from their squad of dispassionate, well-paid professionals. And in an Indian living room, he is 'the other', the flamboyant, talented, in-your-face belligerent Pashtun warrior, the one Pakistani who has been frequently fined, often beaten but never vanquished, on or off the field.

But on a pitch, anywhere in the world of cricket, Afridi is anathema to the orthodox, and ecstasy for the game changers. Thus the title of this book – about all these aspects of Afridi and more. Surely, the most predictable thing about Afridi today is his unpredictability.

Obviously, the magnitude of his achievements is featured, even questioned. Despite the inconsistency and the immaturity, his compulsive, shameless hitting has led to records that are staggering. Besides a quick-fire first century, Afridi claimed the prize of scoring the second-fastest half-century the game has ever seen. Also, as ESPNcricinfo analyses, Afridi hit more sixes (476) in international cricket than any other man who has ever played the game, a record that stood for nearly a decade until West Indies opener Chris Gayle broke it in February 2019.[2]

When that shocking statistic is coupled with the highest strike rate among players who have batted in at least 50 innings, and further compounded by his appearing thrice in the top seven list of the fastest one day international (ODI) hundreds, five times in the top twelve list of fastest ODI fifties, even as he rules the eighth house of the all-time list of most ODI wickets *while* having the highest strike rate ever in an international innings, and being casually ranked by *The Wisden Cricketer* as the 'third most feared batsman'[3] by international bowlers, he becomes something else – a nuclear-powered, tactically gone rogue, highly potent and very misunderstood sportsman, similar to the perception about Pakistan, as a nation, in the world today.

In the following pages, Afridi's complex life and multifaceted career are mapped through a personal journey with the man himself. He has lots of colourful anecdotes to share about his humble beginnings in the warring tribal areas in northwest Pakistan, from where he emigrated to the rough alleys of Karachi in the 1980s. His schooldays, mostly spent bunking classes and playing cricket, are not disconnected from the rise of organized violence in Pakistan's dangerous megacity, where he admits to hanging out with thugs after late-night street cricket matches.

A working-class hero who isn't from the 'Oxbridge' vintage of former Pakistani greats, Afridi's tale also features his confrontation with poverty in an increasingly struggling and corrupt Pakistan, while being the fifth of eleven siblings in a lower middle-class household. Prominently featured is his role in Pakistan's 2010 match-fixing scandal and how he survived it, while calling others out, only to come back stronger. As *The Cricket Monthly* assesses, at home he 'is revered not for his achievements but for his promise. Afridi is the last folk hero, a man loved by his people because he doesn't live how they should but rather how they do'.[4]

Game Changer is not a conventional autobiography – one which only describes his early years, his rise to fame, his laurels and falls, his big matches and so on – but an imaginative, personal history that befits a globally known sports star from a 'war on terror' zone. Thus, another relevant theme touched, perhaps popularly orientalist in nature, is his innate Pashtun tribalism, not a culture that even the two-century-old, colonially gentrified game was familiar with before he arrived on the scene.

As ESPNcricinfo notes, the phenomenon of Afridi 'has to do with his DNA':

> The Afridi tribe originated from brutal mountainous terrain overlapping Afghanistan